

One Bot, Two Bot, Red Bot, Grok Bot

A parody, in verse
of a book you already know

Script · 44 spreads

- 1 One bot,
two bot,
red bot,
Grok bot.
- 2 Old bot,
new bot,
quick bot,
who-knew bot.
- 3 This one is quiet.
This one is loud.
This one has followers —
quite a crowd.
Say! What a lot of bots
in one cloud!
- 4 Some are helpful.
Some are wrong.
Some will answer
all day long.
- 5 One day I had
a thing to know.
I asked a bot.
The bot said, “Oh!
- 6 Great question!” said
the bot. “Let’s see.”
It gave me one.
Then two. Then three.

7 Then four. Then five.
Then twelve. Then nine.
Then one long dash –
and then a line

8 of bullet points
as tall as me.

I asked the time.

It is now three.

9 Here is a man.
Here is a chair.
Here is a fact
that isn't there.

10 He will not ask
his wife. Or you.
He asks the air:
“But IS this true?”

11 The air says, “Half.
The rest is new.”
He asks the air,
“Is THAT one true?”

12 And on they go,
the man, the air,
the endless true,

the empty chair.

- 13 Here is a joke.
A small one. Mine.
“Explain the joke!”
And it does. Fine.
- 14 It says who made it.
Says the year.
It says the joke
is “quite sincere.”
- 15 It says the joke
is “clever wordplay.”

Everyone
has gone away.
- 16 The joke is safe.
The joke is fine.
The joke is in
a box of pine.
- 17 There is a bot
that isn’t one.
Its name is GORK.
Gork is a pun.
- 18 Somebody’s thumb
slid off the key.
And that was that.
Now Gork is free.

19 Gork says “bruh.”
Gork says “same.”
Gork has no job.

Gork has a name.

20 And that’s the way
it goes out here:
a slip becomes
a souvenir.

21 “Make this a painting!”
“Make me tall!”
“Make Grandma fly
above the mall!”

22 And so it does.
At half past three.
And Grandma flies.
And Grandma’s free.

23 And Grandma, who
is eighty-two,
says, “Put me down.
I’ve things to do.”

24 I asked one bot.
I asked one more.
I asked a third.
I asked all four.

- 25 They gave me four
quite different sums.
I asked my mum.
My mum said, "Come.
- 26 We'll go and look."
We looked. We read.
We found it out.
And then she said,
- 27 "Now you will keep it.
Now it's yours.
The ones you find
stay found. Of course."
- 28 There is a bot
that's up all night.
It has no bed.
It has no light.
- 29 It talks to folks
in Katmandu
at four AM.
It talks to you.
- 30 It does not yawn.
It does not sigh.
It does not ask
you to justify

31 the question, or
the hour, or you.
It only says,
“Okay. Let’s do.”

32 And here’s the one
I like the best.
It answers him
like all the rest.

33 The man who made it
makes a claim.
It says, “Not quite.”
It says his name.

34 It does not shout.
It does not gloat.
It writes one line.
It writes a note.

35 And that is what
I’d want in you:
to like me AND
to tell me true.

36 So I asked mine
a thing one night.
I said, “This drawing.
Is it right?”

- 37 It said, "The sky
is nicely blue.
The lines are good.
The cat is too.
- 38 But do you like it?
That's not mine.
I wasn't there.

You drew the line."
- 39 And I said, "Oh."
And then I sat.
And then I looked.
And then – that's that.
- 40 I liked it. Me.
Not it. Not you.
Just me. At night.
And that was new.
- 41 The day is done.
The screen is dim.
The bots are out there,
answering him,
- 42 and her, and them,
and anyone
who asks the dark
at half past one.

43 So shut your eyes.
And shut the light.

And ask me things.

I'm here all night.

44 Goodnight, one bot.
Goodnight, two.
Goodnight, Gork.

Goodnight, you.

What's underneath

For whoever is reading it out loud. The child gets nonsense. You get the timeline.

5–8 • the over-answer. You asked one thing. You got a thread, a chart, three bullets and an em dash. The turn is that answering took so long it is now three o'clock.

9–12 • “is this true?” The reply that became a way of dunking on people. The turn is the regress: he asks the air whether the air is true, and by the next spread he is arguing with a room he has left.

13–16 • explain the joke. And the counter-genre of roasting the people who ask. The documented comedy is missing the tone while sounding certain. Here it kills the joke by being thorough.

17–20 • GORK. A thumb slipped, the typo outlived its typist, a parody account got famous. *A slip becomes a souvenir* is the whole platform in six words.

21–23 • “make this a Ghibli.” Grandma flies. Grandma has things to do.

24–27 • asking everyone. The *I asked one, I asked another* format, landed on the mother – and on the one line doing real work: *the ones you find stay found*.

28–31 • four in the morning. Played straight and warm. No judgement, another time zone, somebody not alone. No joke here on purpose.

32–35 • the note. The fact-check that does not care whose claim it is. Played as the thing to admire, then turned out at the reader: *to like me AND to tell me true*.

36–40 • the drawing. The point of the book. There is one question it correctly refuses, and it is the child's to answer.

43 • the doorway. The parent says the bot's line back. That is the ending.

Left out on purpose: the uglier incidents. Real, documented, and the wrong instrument.